

Module 7: What can you do

Interventions you can do (e.g. research, communications, direct action, protests)

Week 4 | Online-Synchronous | Tuesday

This session brings together the analytical tools introduced earlier in the fellowship and applies them directly to questions of action. Having examined the scale and neglect of farmed animals, the impacts of animal agriculture, and different advocacy approaches, fellows are now invited to think deliberately about **where effort, time, and resources can matter most**.

Rather than asking “what can I do,” this session asks a more practical question: *Given my context, skills, and constraints, how can I contribute in a way that is thoughtful, evidence-informed, and impactful?*

Key Focus

Across the fellowship so far, several recurring questions have emerged:

- Why do some harms persist despite widespread awareness?
- Why do some issues receive attention while others remain neglected?
- Why do some advocacy efforts lead to durable change while others stall?

This module brings these questions together by examining **intervention pathways**—the concrete ways advocates attempt to shift systems, institutions, norms, and policies.

Intervention Pathways in Animal Advocacy

Research and Evidence Generation

Research-based interventions include welfare assessments, scoping studies, policy analysis, and data collection. These approaches are especially relevant when problems are poorly understood, contested, or dismissed, and when evidence is required to unlock institutional or policy change. Research does not, on its own, create change, but it often determines which changes become possible.

Policy and Legal Advocacy

Policy and legal interventions aim to change laws, regulations, and formal standards, including bans, protections, enforcement mechanisms, and institutional mandates. These approaches often involve long timelines and political negotiation, but can create

system-wide and durable effects once adopted. Policy change frequently reflects prior shifts in evidence, public norms, and political pressure.

Institutional and Corporate Change

This pathway focuses on shifting practices within universities, companies, public institutions, and supply chains. Examples include procurement reform, standards adoption, and institutional commitments. While often incremental, institutional change can affect large numbers of animals relatively quickly and may serve as a bridge between voluntary action and formal regulation.

Farmer Engagement and Production-Side Transition

Farmer engagement focuses on working directly with producers—particularly smallholders—to change on-farm practices through training, technical assistance, pilot programs, and transition support. This pathway is especially relevant in contexts where:

- production is decentralized,
- farmers face real economic and biosecurity constraints, and
- adversarial or purely consumer-facing approaches are unlikely to succeed.

Farmer engagement often emphasizes harm reduction, feasibility, and trust-building, and can serve as an entry point for welfare improvements or longer-term structural change.

Movement Building and Agenda-Setting

Movement-based interventions focus on coalition building, agenda-setting, and constituency formation. This includes national or sectoral agendas, youth platforms, and coordinated campaigns that expand political and moral space for change. These efforts shape what becomes thinkable, legitimate, and demandable within public discourse and policy arenas.

Communications and Narrative Change

Narrative interventions work to reshape how animals, food systems, and justice are understood. This includes media work, public education, cultural interventions, and reframing dominant assumptions. Narrative change often operates upstream of policy and institutional reform by influencing norms, values, and priorities.

Direct Action and Disruptive Advocacy

Direct action includes protests, demonstrations, boycotts, occupations, and other forms of nonviolent disruption intended to challenge unjust systems, force public attention, or alter power dynamics. This pathway is often used when:

- institutional channels are closed or unresponsive,
- harms are urgent or extreme, and
- incremental approaches are insufficient.

Direct action can accelerate change but carries higher risks, including legal, personal, and movement-level consequences. Its effectiveness depends heavily on context, strategy, and public legitimacy.

Individual Behavior Change

Interventions focused on personal choices—such as dietary change—can reduce harm directly and contribute to broader cultural shifts. On their own, they are limited; when combined with institutional, policy, or narrative change, they can reinforce systems-level transformation.

Why These Pathways Are Listed Together

No single intervention pathway is sufficient on its own. Across contexts, effective advocacy often involves sequencing and combination, such as:

- research enabling policy change,
- farmer engagement informing institutional standards,
- direct action shifting public discourse, or
- movement-building making policy victories durable.

Reflection

Please answer briefly. Bullet points or short phrases are sufficient.

1. Looking back across Modules 1–6, which **problem area** in animal agriculture or food systems feels most urgent or compelling to you right now?
2. Which **intervention pathway** discussed in this module do you currently feel most drawn to as an entry point for action? *(For example: research, policy or legal advocacy, institutional or corporate change, farmer engagement and production-side transition, movement building, communications and narrative change, direct action, or individual behavior change.)*
3. What is **one constraint or trade-off** that this intervention pathway would need to navigate in your context?
4. Based on your skills, access, and limits, what would a **realistic first step** look like if you were to pursue this pathway?

Note: There are no correct answers. This reflection is intended to support clarity and self-awareness, not to lock you into a single advocacy path.